A Prize Possession

Geetanjali Shree, *66*
Author

GEETANJALI SHREE REMEMBERS being surrounded by books at home during her childhood. "Reading was a valued pastime and my father was a serious Hindi writer," she reminisces. In 2022, Geetanjali's own book, *Ret Samadhi*, translated from the Hindi into English by Daisy Rockwell as *Tomb of Sand*, cemented her name as the first writer in any South Asian language to win the International Booker Prize.

Geetanjali fondly recalls the influence of her childhood years on her literary journey. Her father was a civil servant, and her family moved across several UP towns. "My family reflected the ways of many middle class families of the time—we studied in the supposedly better English-medium schools but read and learnt our mother tongue at home, and respected language, literature, learning." Growing up in various towns connected her to her roots, she says. Apart from Premchand, on whose work Geetanjali did a Ph.D., she was deeply influenced by other authors like Renu, Krishna Sobti, Intezar Husain, to mention "just a very few nearer home".

Geetanjali's first published story, *Bel Patra*, appeared in 1987. Her debut novel *Mai* made her well-known; its Sahitya Akademi award-winning English translation extended its fame. The novel, based on three generations of women, challenged simplistic notions of what women's freedom means. "Books are made of many things.... We carry the world in us, in our conscious and subconscious layers. It is made of our observation, our imagination, dreams and despairs. All that is needed is a trigger," she says. For *Ret Samadhi*, it was the image "of an elderly back, the back of one who seems done with life and waiting to go. It turned into someone who is... raring to go into another innings". Geetanjali is conscious of the challenges of being a woman author. "There are systemic ways the mainstream, which is very male, extends its patriarchal gaze on everyone," she says. ■

-Harshita Mishra

ACCOMPLISHMENT

In 2022, her novel *Ret Samadhi*, translated into English as *Tomb of Sand*, won the International Booker Prize. Her fiction stands out for exploring women's freedom



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

STARTING POINT

"The point to start from is where you are. Don't be cramped"

↘ FAVOURITE BOOK
Mahabharata

↘ WAYS OF BEING
Reading, music, travelling, being with nice people, doing nothing